A Child's Book of Sickness and Death

By Chris Adrian

CINDY: **(Pg 177)** Ella Thims sits in her little red wagon by the clerk's desk. Ella had some trouble finishing up her nether parts, and was born without a colon, or most of her small intestine, and her kidneys are shaped like spirals. She's only two. I've known her all her life. *(Beat)* **(Pg 196)** Ella Thims died in the PICU, killed, it was discovered, by too much potassium in her sauce. A newly graduated nurse meticulously verified the poisonous contents of the solution and delivered them without comment. It put her heart in that bad rhythm they couldn't get her out of, though they worked over her till dawn. She'd been at it for a while before she was discovered, so it was already too late when they put her on the bypass machine. It made her dead alive - her blood was moving in her, but by midmorning of the next day she was rotting inside.

INTRODUCTION

According to the University of Michigan, a chronic illness is "a long-lasting condition that can be controlled but not cured. Examples in children include diabetes, cancer, organ failure, and for the two children in this story, short-gut syndrome. For these children, hospitals become a second home and the doctors and nurses who care for them, a second family.

Cindy faces sickness and death on a regular basis; but she's developed a way of coping. She's become an author of her own book . . .

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CINDY: **(Pg 172)** My room, 616, is always waiting for me when I get back, unless it is the dead of winter, rotavirus season, when the floor is crowded with gray-faced toddlers rocketing down the halls. They are only transiently ill, and not distinguished. You earn something in a lifetime of hospitalizations that the rotavirus babies, the RSV wheezers, the accidental ingestions, the rare tonsillectomy, that these sub-sub-sickees could never touch. The least of it is the sign that the nurses have hung above my door, silver glitter on red poster board: *Chez Cindy*.

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(Pg 174) [You see] I am a former twenty-six week miracle preemie. When I was born you were pretty much dead if you emerged at twenty-six weeks. I did well except for a belly infection that took about a foot of my gut -- nothing a big person would miss but it was a lot to me. So I've got difficult bowels. I don't absorb well, and get this horrible pain, and barf like mad, and need tube feeds, and beyond that I sometimes have to go on the sauce, [that's] TPN - total parenteral nutrition - where they skip my wimpy little gut and feed me through my veins. **(Pg 196)** *(softly)* Ella Thims died by too much potassium in her sauce.

(Pg 174) I am waiting for my PICC- you must have central access to go back on the sauce- when a Child Life person comes rapping at my door. You can always tell when it's them because they knock so politely, and because they call out so politely: "May I come in? **(Pg 175)** We are collaborating with the children. A collaboration of poetry and prose!"

I want to say, people like you wear me out, honey. If you don't go away soon I know my heart will stop beating from weariness, but I let her go on. When she asks if I will make a submission to their hospital literary magazine I say, "Sure!" I won't, though. I am working on my own project, a child's book of sickness and death, and cannot spare thoughts or words for [Margaret]. *(as if she's been asked a question)* **(Pg 178)** My book? The cat and the bunny and the peacock and the pony, each delightful creature afflicted with a uniquely horrible disease. *(as if the audience has responded negatively)* There's a book -- Everybody Poops. Why not one that's just about sickness and death? Everybody poops. Everybody suffers. Everybody dies.

(Pg 173-174) *(She reads from her manuscript)* *See the cat? The cat has feline leukemic indecisiveness. He is losing his fur, and his cheeks are hurting him terribly, and he bleeds from out of his nose and his ears. His eyes are bad. He can hardly see you. Suffer, cat, suffer!*

(Pg 172) *(to the audience)* If you are the sort of child who only comes into the hospital once every ten years, then the whole world comes to visit, and your room is filled with flowers and chocolates and aluminum balloons.

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(Pg 177) *See the pony? She has dreadful hoof dismay. She gets a terrible pain every time she tries to walk, and yet she is very restless, and can hardly stand to sit still. Late at night her hooves whisper at her as cruelly as anyone who ever hated her. She hardly knows how she feels about them anymore, her hooves, because they hurt her so much, yet they are still so very pretty - her best feature, everyone say s- and biting them very hard is the only thing that makes her feel any better at all. Suffer, pony, suffer!*

(Pg 172) *(a soft echo of thought as she turns the page)* After the tenth or fifteenth admission, the people and the flowers stop coming.

(Pg 182) *See the zebra? She has atrocious pancreas, oh! Her belly hurts her terribly - sometimes it's like frogs are crawling in her belly, and sometimes it's like snakes are biting her inside just below her belly button, and sometimes it's a pain she can't even describe. Suffer, zebra, suffer!*

(Pg 172) *(a soft echo of thought as she turns the page)* My room, 616, is always waiting for me when I get back.

(Pg 186-187) *See the peacock? He has crispy lung surprise. He has got an aching in his chest, and every time he tries to say something nice to someone, he only coughs. His breath stinks so much it makes everyone run away, and he tries to run away from it himself, but of course no matter where he goes, he can still smell it. Sometimes he holds his breath, just to escape it, until he passes out, but he always wakes up, even when he would rather not. He only feels ashamed now when he spreads out his feathers. Suffer, peacock, suffer!*

(Pg 172) *(a soft echo of thought as she turns the page)* Gray-*faced toddlers rocketing down the halls*

(Pg 192-193) *See the bunny? She has high colonic ruin, a very fancy disease. Only bunnies from the very best families get it, but when she cries bloody tears and the terrible spiders come crawling out of her bottom, she would rather be poo., When her pillow feeds her*

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dreams of happy bunnies playing in the snow, she only feels jealous and sad, and she bites her tongue while she sleeps, and bleeds all night. In the morning a servant drives her to the Potty Club, where she sits with other wealthy bunny girls on a row of crystal toilets. They are supposed to be her friends, but she doesn't like them at all. Suffer, bunny, suffer!

(Pg 196) *(a soft echo of thought as she turns the page)* Ella Thims died in the PICU

See the cat? He has died. Feline leukemic indecisiveness is always terminal. Now he just lies there. You can pick him up. Go ahead. He will be smellier in the morning, but no more alive. Maybe he is in a better place, maybe his illness could not follow him where he went, or maybe everything is the same, the same pain in a different place. Maybe there is nothing at all, where he is. Goodbye, cat, goodbye!

(Pg 198) All the sadness of the past twenty-four hours ought to count for something, ought to change something, inside of me, or outside in the world. But I expect that nothing will change - children have died here before, and hapless idiots have come and gone, and always the next day the sick still come to languish and be poked, and they will lie in bed hoping, not for healing, but for something to make them feel better, just for a little while. I think of my animals and hear them all, not just the cat but the whole bloated menagerie, crying and crying, *make it stop*.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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